

The 5 things I check *first on any swing*

Pull up tonight's phone video and look for these five things, in this order. Real reps below, so you know exactly what each one looks like.

01 The launch position

The actual stance doesn't matter. Open, closed, square, tall, crouched, none of it matters. What matters is the launch position: the spot every good hitter gets to right as the pitcher is about to release the ball, after a simple load. Different stance, same launch position, every time. That is the checkpoint, not the stance.



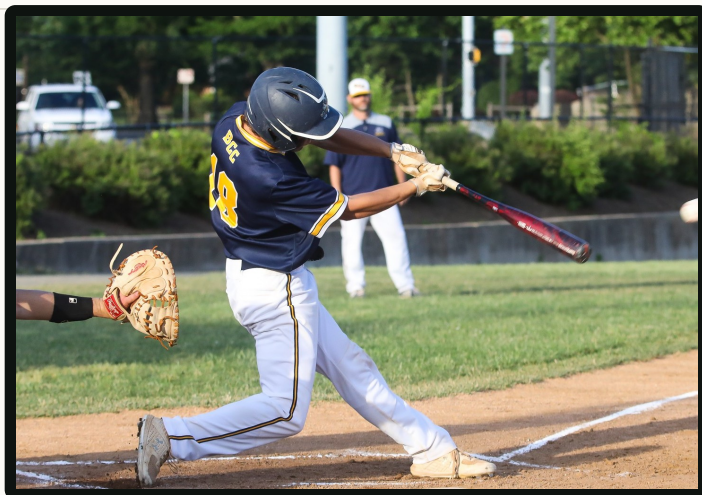
02 Hands inside the ball

Watch the hands from load to contact. They should stay close to the body, tucked near the ribs and back shoulder, and travel on a short, direct line into the ball instead of sweeping away from the body first. That long, looping path out and around, casting, is the single biggest killer of a simple, compact, powerful swing. Short and direct beats long and loopy almost every time.



03 Balance, and contact out front

Freeze the video right at contact. The head should sit still and roughly stacked over the belt, not falling toward the pitcher or drifting off the back foot. Then check where contact actually happens relative to the body: it should be out in front of the lead foot, not deep or even with it. Balanced through the head, with contact out front, is where real contact quality lives.



04 Extension through the baseball

Right after contact, the arms should keep extending out through the ball instead of stopping short. A swing that gets through the baseball drives the ball. A swing that just punches at it and pulls back in does not. This is where a lot of power quietly gets left on the table.



05 The finish

Last checkpoint. The back shoulder should end up facing the pitcher and the back foot should release naturally onto the toe. If the swing stops dead right after contact, or only the arms keep moving while the body stays closed off, the rotation stopped early somewhere upstream.



None of this replaces real reps. But knowing exactly what to look for, in this order, is the fastest way to know what to actually work on next.

— COACH COLE

TOP OF THE 1ST

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